



**TREE OF LIFE INTERNATIONAL
CHURCHES(TOLIC)**
Pastors Manual

Introduction

This manual provides a brief overview of what a Tree of Life churches(TOLIC) does and believes, plus resources to help our pastors in key aspects of their ministry. The manual is updated in December each year with new resources that come to hand.

Tree of Life International Churches(TOLIC)

History:

The Tree of Life International Churches originated in Lagos, Nigeria in 1993. The first founding Pastors were Apostle John and Rev Stella Ebegbuna. They started in a living room with less than ten people. Apostle John and Stella Ebegbuna heard the call to prepare the Bride of Christ for the second coming and to call the churches Tree of Life.

The focus was to reach the unreached and the unchurched with the good news of Jesus Christ and to bring them into the body of Christ with strong emphasis on discipleship(Passion for Jesus and lifestyle) and reproduction.

The ministry remained loyal to the local call until the LORD Jesus led them into international branches through the Tree of Life Zambia which was started by Rev Trudy N'gandu. From then the movement TOLIC movement has spread to other African nations and it is still spreading.

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The church

Becoming a branch of Tree of Life International Churches

New churches are added to the Tree of Life International Churches through church planting and (occasionally) through adoption.

Church planting is fundamental to the Tree of Life International churches' philosophy of evangelism and extending the kingdom of God, and all our congregations are encouraged to be churches that plant churches. For more information on church planting within the Tree of Life International Churches please email us at info@treeoflifeinternationalchurches.org

When an existing church wants to be adopted into the Tree of Life International Churches movement, there is normally a long process of walking side-by-side to clearly establish that the church in question has Tree of Life International Churches values in its DNA. For more information on becoming a branch of Tree of Life International Churches, contact our international office, info@treeoflifeinternationalchurches.org or treeoflifechurch@yahoo.com

Church meetings

Tree of Life International churches are to hold at least two church services a week, plus home groups and other midweek meetings appropriate to their size and style of ministry.

Services typically include worship, preaching and ministry, and as churches grow more substantial children's and/or youth ministry.

Other ingredients we would encourage regularly include communion, an invitation for people to accept Christ, Holy Ghost Baptism and an opportunity for people to build relationships with each other.

We would also encourage churches to hold regular baptism services (at least twice annually).

Each church and pastor is encouraged to seek God as to the style of ministry best suited to a particular church community. However, TOLIC urges its churches to be faithful to the Tree of Life International Churches vision and mission statements, guiding principles, genetic code and values as outlined in this document.

Statement of faith

1. We believe in the Scriptures of the Old and New Testaments, in their original writing, as fully inspired of God and accept them as the supreme and final authority for faith and life.
2. We believe in one God, eternally existing in three Persons – Father, Son and Holy Spirit.
3. We believe that Jesus Christ was begotten of the Father, conceived by the Holy Spirit, born of the Virgin Mary and is true God and true man.
4. We believe that God created man in His own image; that man sinned and thereby incurred the penalty of sin which is death physically and spiritually; that all human beings inherit a sinful nature which issues (in the case of those who reach moral responsibility) in actual transgression involving personal guilt.
5. With regards to sexual behaviour, we believe in heterosexual relationships between a natural man and a natural woman within the confines of lawful matrimony.
6. We believe that the Lord Jesus Christ died for our sins a substitutionary sacrifice according to the Scriptures and that all who believe in Him are justified on the grounds of His shed blood.
7. We believe in the bodily resurrection of the Lord Jesus, His ascension into Heaven, and His present life as our High Priest and Advocate.
8. We believe in the personal return of the Lord Jesus Christ.
9. We believe that all who repent of their sin and receive the Lord Jesus Christ by faith are born again of the Holy Spirit and thereby become children of God.
10. We believe in the baptism in the Holy Spirit, empowering and equipping believers for service, with the accompanying supernatural gifts of the Holy Spirit; and in fellowship with the Holy Spirit. We believe in the divinely ordained ministries of Apostle, Prophet, Evangelist, Pastor and Teacher.
11. With regards to submission to authority, we believe in the principle of being in authority because you are under authority. As such, it is understood that membership shall be subject to submission to authority in matters pertaining to church governance, doctrine and personal behaviour.
12. We believe in the resurrection of both the just and the unjust, the eternal blessedness of the redeemed, and the eternal banishment of those who have rejected the offer of salvation.
13. We believe that the one true Church is the whole company of those who have been redeemed by Jesus Christ and regenerated by the Holy Spirit; that the local church on earth should take its character from this concept of the Church spiritual

and therefore, that the new birth and personal confession of Christ are essentials of church membership.

14. We believe that the Lord Jesus Christ appointed two ordinances – Baptism in water and the Lord's Supper to be observed as acts of obedience and as perpetual witnesses to the cardinal facts of the Christian faith, that Baptism is the immersion of the believer in water as a confession of identification with Christ in burial and resurrection and that the Lord's Supper is the partaking of the emblems symbolic of the Saviour's broken body and shed blood, in remembrance of His sacrificial death, until he comes.

15. We believe that divine healing was provided for in the Old and New Testament and is an integral part of the Gospel.

16. We believe that the Bible teaches that without holiness no man can see the Lord. We believe in the doctrine of sanctification as a definite, yet progressive work of grace, commencing at the time of the new birth and continuing until the consummation of salvation.

17. We believe the Leadership of the local church has the authority from the scriptures to withdraw the membership of any member for serious, unrepentant misconduct or similar cause.

18. The Church is open to any further truth, which the Holy Spirit may illuminate from the Scriptures.

Church Finances

Tree of Life International churches are financed by their congregation members, who are encouraged to give generously as part of their commitment to and relationship with Jesus Christ. The churches are expected to receive tithe and offering/collections from the members and worshippers.

Our churches are asked to tithe (10%) their income (out of their total monthly tithe and offering collected) to Tree of Life International Churches International Headquarters. This is to be sent to the International Headquarters via the TOLIC national headquarters office.

The rest of their income:

From the remaining 90%, 10% should go to the national headquarters for running costs and the remaining 80% can be used for buildings, wages and ministries at the discretion of the local church leaders.

For transparency and accountability reasons we encourage:

- Two people to count the offerings, and two to sign cheques.
- Accounts to be assessed yearly by an independent accountant.

Keeping statistics

Statistics are an important window on the health of a church. The Tree of Life International Churches collects statistics each year, which helps the national leadership team know how the movement is going. Statistics we collect each year

include:

1. Attendance at church services – divided between adults (13-plus) and children (under 13)
2. Offerings
3. Number of conversions
4. Number of baptisms

Appointing staff

Once a church gets to a certain size, the appointment of extra staff is essential. Often churches get stuck at certain sizes because their existing staff numbers can't effectively minister to any more people. A good staff member should earn his or her salary within six months by the increased congregation that he/she will promote.

Don't assume that the second staff member should be an assistant pastor. A good administrator/PA can often better release a pastor into his/her calling, while sometimes a church grows by creating new departments that reach a new circle of people. Only appoint staff when you can't fill the gap with a volunteer.

Suggestions for finding the right staff member:

- Pray for God's leading.
- Appoint staff who will reach people you are not effectively reaching.
- Write a detailed job description so you can ascertain whether the person in question fits right.
- Look for someone with different strengths but similar vision. The new staff member needs to love you, love your church and love your vision – and then be let loose to fulfil their calling within the wider vision and purpose of the church.
- Ascertain whether he/she is a person of initiative. Is he/she a self-starter or will he/she need supervision all the time?
- Remember that we value character over giftedness.
- Look for a person with more than one ability administrator/musician; youth/pastoral care etc.
- Check out previous work history (including secular employment).

THE GENERAL OVERSEER HAS THE FINAL SAY AS TO WHO IS APPOINTED. ALL PROSPECTIVE PASTORAL CANDIDATES NAMES MUST BE FORWARDED TO THE NATIONAL HEADQUARTERS FOR FORWARDING TO THE GENERAL OVERSEER (AT THE INTERNATIONAL HEADQUARTERS) FOR APPROVAL OR REJECTION.

Choosing leaders

We encourage our churches and pastors to take time before recommending leaders/elders etc. When you do so, make sure they are people of the same heart and vision and they must be in agreement with our statement of faith.

Appointing a new senior pastor

When a senior pastor is thinking about leaving a church, it is essential that he/she talks to the church's leadership and the Tree of Life International Churches national

director early in the process. This will help facilitate a successful transition of leadership.

The process of finding a senior pastor will normally be handled by the outgoing senior pastor and his/her church leadership team, with reference to the national director. Often the new pastor will be a member of the existing congregation, though at times there may be others available within the Tree of Life International Churches who the national director may know about. When the new senior pastor is found to the satisfaction of the leadership team and the national director, his or her name will be forwarded to the General Overseer at the International Headquarters and if approved an ordination service will be arranged.

Suggestions for . . . running great services

A church's main meeting is the "front door" of that congregation and it is therefore essential that the church concentrates hard on getting it right.

Make sure the service has been thought and and prayed through well before the meeting itself. It helps for each service to have a theme and a goal that the pastor feels God has put on his/her heart. This doesn't mean rigidly sticking to a programme, but having confidence in the direction the Holy Spirit is leading. While some say too much preparation diminishes the opportunity for the Holy Spirit to move, it is also true that preparation provides a framework within which the Holy Spirit moves.

Concentrate hard on the beginning of the service – the opening prayer/greeting/song etc; the transitions between aspects of the service – worship to notices, notices to preaching, preaching to ministry etc; and finish strongly.

The preacher should be well-prepared, theologically sound and in tune with both the Holy Spirit and the congregation. Good questions to ask of the preacher include: In one sentence, what are you trying to say? Do you have a good mix of points and illustrations? What do you hope people will take away?

The senior pastor, the preacher and the worship leader (one person will sometimes fill more than one of these roles) must be in harmony, with the senior pastor having the final say in what happens in the service.

Regularly give the opportunity for people to accept Christ as Saviour; to be filled with the Spirit; to re-dedicate themselves to the Lord, etc.

Our mandatory Church Services

Sundays:

1st Sunday of the month- Thanksgiving Service

2nd Sunday Celebration Service and Holy Communion

3rd Sunday: Celebration Service

Last Sunday: Guest Service(a service to target the unbelievers. (Invite guests and

hold an evangelistic service).

Tuesday or Wednesday: Midweek Bible Study.

Friday: Night vigil/tarry night or evening prayer meeting.

Fasting: Tree of Life International Churches holds a yearly general fasting apart from local the fasting expected at the local assembly level.

Apart from this all Ministers are expected to live a fasted life.

MARRIAGE

Step One

Tree of Life International Churches courtship/engaged couples workshop is the best first step to take and then mentoring follows to build godly principles into your relationship. Our desire is to serve and celebrate with you as you plan your wedding day. It is part of Tree of Life International Churches provides pre-marital counselling for all couples planning to get married.

Pastors please note: Intending couples are to be referred to a reputable doctor chosen by the leadership of the local assembly for Pregnancy tests, Blood test and genotype test. This is to determine whether the lady is pregnant outside of wedlock, whether their blood groups are compatible and also for HIV/AIDS screening.

Weddings

Our marriage celebrants are not obliged to marry everyone who asks, but of course marrying a couple in your church is one of the highlights of ministry life.

We recommend that couples getting married undergo some form of premarital counselling, either by the pastor or someone else who has been trained within the church. Pre-marital counselling is an ideal opportunity to resolve any outstanding issues in the couple's lives.

Here are some suggestions in conducting marriage services:

- Be aware of people's pasts both morally and legally. You will have to decide what your position is on marrying divorcees or marrying a Christian to a non-Christian. It is also important to ascertain clearly that both parties to the marriage are legally able to be married.
- Make sure you meet with the couple at least three months before the wedding to plan the big day. The service can take any shape or form, but to fulfil the law there must be a clear declaration made by the couple about their commitment to marriage, such as, "I (a.b.) take you (c.d.) to be my legal wife/husband." The wedding documents also have to be signed and witnessed (which takes a surprisingly long time during the service, so make sure there is music or some kind of activity to cover it).
- A wedding day is a wonderful opportunity to present Christ in a sensitive and loving way.

- As the celebrant you have the great honour of guiding the couple and their families through what is often a nerve-wracking, yet exciting day. Do this with integrity and good humour.

Possible ingredients in a wedding order of service:

1. Entrance of the bridal party
2. Welcome and opening prayer
3. Worship/hymn/song
4. Scripture reading
5. Message
6. Giving of the bride and groom
7. Charge to witnesses
8. Rings
9. Vows and exchange of rings
10. Pronouncement and kissing bride
11. Prayer for bridal couple
12. Communion
13. Signing register
14. Final prayer and presentation of married couple

Wedding vows

Option # 1

I, [insert name], take you, [insert name], to be my wife/husband. I promise to love, respect and honour you above all others. I will comfort you, and support you in all that you do. I pledge to you my complete trust and faithfulness, now and from this day forward.

Option # 2

Minister: Do you, [insert name], take [insert name] to be your lawful wedded wife/husband?

Groom and Bride: I do

Minister: Please repeat after me

I promise before God and these witnesses to be your loving and faithful husband/wife, in plenty and in want, in joy and in sorrow, in sickness and in health, as long as we both shall live.

Option # 3

Minister: [Insert name], will you have [insert name] to be your wife/husband, to live together in the covenant of marriage? Will you love her/him, comfort her/him, honour and keep her/him? Will you forsake all others and be faithful to her/him as long as you both shall live?

Groom and Bride: I will.

Option # 4

I, [insert name], take you, [insert name], to be my wife/husband. I promise before God, my family and friends, to love you always, and to respect and honour you above all others. I will comfort you and support you in all that you do. I give you

my complete trust, honesty and faithfulness today and forever.

Option # 5

Groom and Bride: In the presence of God, our family and friends, I take you to be my husband/wife from this day forward. I will trust and honour you, I will cherish our friendship and love you always, through the best and the worst, through the difficult and the easy. I promise to support, encourage and stand up for you, I promise to share and be patient, to be truthful and honest, to console and comfort and to enjoy our time together.

Option # 6

[Insert name] I love you, and today before God, our family and friends, I commit myself to be your wife/husband. I promise to love and respect you always. I cherish you as my best friend and promise to encourage, support and pray for you in all things. No matter what life brings, I will be with you. I pledge to you my complete honesty, trust and faithfulness now and from this day forward.

Ring vows

Option # 1

Groom and Bride: I give you this ring, before God, as a symbol of my love and a sign of my promise.

Option # 2

Minster: The wedding rings which you are both now to give and receive serve as a symbol of the vows you have just taken. They are outward and visible signs of the inward and invisible love which binds your hearts together.

Groom and Bride: [Insert name], I promise to love and respect you, to honour and trust you above all others, to cherish and comfort you, to be your greatest encourager and your best friend. I give you this ring before God as a symbol of my love and a sign of my promise.

Option # 3

Groom and Bride: I place this ring on your finger as a reminder and pledge of our constant and abiding love.

Baptisms

BAPTISMAL CEREMONY INSTRUCTIONS FOR PASTORS:

Pray before the Baptismal Service.

Be sure the people are converted.

Prepare certificate to give to each baptismal Candidate after their Baptism.

Baptism must be done by immersion. The person is to be immersed only once in the name of the Father, Son and the Holy Spirit.¹⁹ Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost (Matthew 28:19 "Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, **baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost.**")

They are to be dressed in clothing that covers them properly and that will not be transparent when wet.

Towels should be provided to wrap the candidates in immediately after service.

BAPTISM

Baptism is a key part of a Christian's journey of faith and we encourage Tree of Life International churches to give regular (at least twice yearly) opportunity for new believers to be baptised. It is surprising how many existing Christians haven't been baptised, too, so don't assume everyone in your congregation has been baptised.

So what is baptism?

First up it's a ceremony set in place (ordained) by Jesus. There were two ceremonies He specifically commanded his followers to perform – baptism and communion. Regarding baptism he said, "Go to the people of all nations and make them my disciples. Baptise them in the name of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit, and teach them to do everything I have told you" (Matthew 28:19). Jesus himself submitted to baptism even though he had no sins to be cleansed of.

Other baptism scriptures can be found in Matthew 3:13-16, Mark 1 and Luke 3.

In baptism the believer (who should be able to give a credible profession of faith in Jesus) is willingly immersed in water and raised up again to signify his or her faith as a follower of Jesus. The person baptising should ask if Jesus is indeed their Lord and then say words like, "On your profession of faith and at your own request, I baptise you in the name of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit."

The Greek word "baptizo" means to plunge, immerse or dip something in water – in case you were wondering.

Baptism is a spiritual transaction signifying many things, including:

- It's the outward sign of our inward change, our public statement of being a follower of Jesus. "On that day about three thousand believed his (Peter's) message and were baptised. They spent their time learning from the apostles and they were like family to each other" (Acts 2:41-42).
- It symbolises the passing/death of our old life. A new life has begun and our emergence from the water is the sign of our spiritual rebirth. "When you were baptised, it was the same as being buried with Christ. Then you were raised to life because you had faith in the power of God, who raised Christ from death" (Colossians 2:12).
- It signifies our union with Christ in his death and resurrection. "Don't you know that all who share in Christ Jesus by being baptised also share in his death? When we were baptised, we died and were buried with Christ. We were baptised, so that we would live a new life, as Christ was raised to life by the glory of God the Father. If we shared in Jesus' death by being baptised, we will be raised to life with him. We know that the persons we used to be were nailed to the cross with Jesus. This was done, so that our sinful bodies would no longer be the slaves of sin. We know that sin doesn't have power over dead people" (Romans 6:3-7).
- It symbolises the washing away of our sins. "What are you waiting for? Get up! Be baptised, and wash away your sins by praying to the Lord" (Acts 22:16).
- It is a sign of entrance into the Body of Christ, the Church. "The body of Christ

has many different parts ... but God's Spirit baptised each of us and made us part of the body of Christ" (1 Corinthians 12:12-13).

- Above all, it's our response to the Good News of Jesus. "Turn back to God! Be baptised in the name of Jesus Christ, so that your sins will be forgiven" (Acts 2:37-38).

The symbolism of going into the grave and being raised up from it is very strong and this can be taken further by looking back into the Old Testament and seeing how God used water and floods to pass judgement on sinful people, as with Noah, and also the Egyptians who were swept away after the Israelites had passed safely through the Red Sea. There's Jonah too. So those who go down into the waters of baptism are, in a way, going into the waters of judgement and death. When they come back up it shows they've safely passed through the judgement of God because of Jesus, with whom they are united in his death and resurrection (1 Peter 3:19-21).

Since baptism is the sign of entrance into the body of Christ, the Church, it is fitting that it be done in the presence of other believers, so the whole church can celebrate and their faith can be built up. Baptism encourages and strengthens and brings blessing to the participants and spectators alike.

Funerals

Visiting the sick, comforting the bereaved and conducting funerals are difficult yet privileged roles for pastors. Our presence, sympathy and comfort is often essential to the family who are suffering the loss. The average family calling a minister at the approach of death or immediately after will be facing a new experience. If you as the pastor can help them work through the many issues they will face in the lead-up to the funeral, you will truly be a blessing. In this regard, work closely with the funeral directors – they are professionals and know better than anyone what to do and when.

Preparation for the funeral demands thought and care. A balance between sorrow and celebration of a life lived is important, plus of course the hope we have of new life in Christ.

Scriptures you may like to explore include Psalm 23, 1 Corinthians 15 (especially verses 35-58), 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18, John 14:1-7 and Revelation 21. The Christian funeral service should contain notes of hope, victory and assurance. Funerals for non-believers are harder, without hope of life to come. Regardless, the service itself is a great opportunity to sensitively point people to Christ.